

Abusive Buyer Policy

Official eBay Standards Defining Unacceptable Buying Behavior, Including Return/Refund Fraud (Real Policy Text)

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Source

This document reproduces the official eBay Abusive Buyer Policy, retrieved from ebay.com (eBay Inc.). It is real, live platform policy text that defines unacceptable buying behavior, including return/refund fraud patterns. This policy is the closest real-world equivalent to an internal fraud/escalation policy that a major e-commerce platform publishes openly.

1. Policy Overview

This policy outlines eBay's expectations for buyer behavior. Buyers may not misuse feedback, returns, buyer protection programs, or payment dispute processes. When buyers don't meet these standards, sellers can report abusive behavior.

When eBay reviews a report of a member violating policy, it looks at the circumstances, including the members' history. Decisions are made based on the evidence in the individual situation, as well as by evaluating patterns of behavior that create negative value in the marketplace. If eBay isn't sure about something, it may not take any action. Because eBay respects members' privacy, it cannot discuss the results of any investigations with third parties.

2. Demanding Something Not Offered in the Original Listing

Not Allowed	Allowed
Requesting a shipping service not offered by the seller	Selecting one of the shipping services offered by the seller at checkout
Requesting the seller ship to an address other than the one used at checkout	Updating address in eBay account before checkout
Requesting to use a payment method not offered at checkout	Paying through a payment option offered at checkout
Requesting the seller hold the item for later payment	Paying for the item within 4 days

Not Allowed	Allowed
Requesting a partial refund without returning the item	Returning an item in accordance with the seller's returns policy
Requesting additional items/services not in the listing, or asking for a discount	Purchasing items according to the terms in the original listing
Finding an item on eBay and taking the sale off eBay	Finding an item on eBay and completing the sale on eBay

3. Making False Claims

Not Allowed	Allowed
Claiming an item was not received when there is proof of delivery to the address on the Order details page	Claiming an item was not received when it has not been delivered by the latest estimated delivery date
Falsely claiming an item was not as described	Claiming an item was not as described when it genuinely did not match the listing

4. Misusing Returns

Not Allowed	Allowed
Returning an item other than the original item received	Returning the original item received, in its original condition
Using or damaging an item and then returning it	(see Condition of Returned Items Policy for deduction rules)
Returning an item claiming it was not as described when it was described accurately	Returning an item as not as described when it was described inaccurately

This section, combined with the Condition of Returned Items Policy, directly addresses claims such as a customer attempting to return a functioning, undamaged item (e.g., an unbroken pair of earphones) while claiming it is defective. This constitutes "falsely claiming an item was not as described" and/or "returning an item claiming it was not as described when it was described accurately," both explicitly listed as not allowed.

5. Not Following Messaging, Bidding, or Cancellation Policies

Not Allowed	Allowed
Sending messages to force or intimidate a seller into something outside the original agreement	Using messages to ask clarifying questions about listing descriptions or terms
Sending messages requesting order cancellation when cancellations aren't allowed	Retracting a bid only under exceptional circumstances
Bidding on and winning an auction but failing to pay	—

6. Abusing Buyer Protection Programs or Payment Dispute Processes

Not Allowed	Allowed
Opening duplicate requests using other buyer protection programs	Opening an eBay Money Back Guarantee case (or another program's case) when the item didn't match the listing
Harassing sellers about a non-received item before the latest estimated delivery date has passed	Opening a case when the item wasn't received and the issue couldn't be resolved with the seller
Opening a buyer protection case after already receiving a refund from the seller, or without having paid	—
Opening a case as retaliation against a seller following a previous dispute	—
Initiating a payment dispute after already receiving a refund or reimbursement for the same transaction	—
Filing duplicate or excessive payment disputes	—

7. Not Paying for Items

Buyers must pay for items within 4 calendar days or the seller can cancel the order. For eBay Live auctions, immediate payment is required; if payment is unsuccessful, the seller may cancel the order immediately. Buyers who have excessive unpaid items or canceled orders may have limits imposed on their account, or lose their buying privileges.

8. Related Policy Areas (Escalation-Adjacent)

- Communications: buyer-seller communications must follow the Member-to-Member Contact Policy.
- Customs declarations: asking a seller to falsely declare an item as a gift on a customs form is considered encouraging illegal activity.
- Contact information: eBay takes action when a member has false or missing contact information.
- Multiple accounts: registering new accounts, or using existing ones, to avoid buying restrictions, limits, or other policy consequences is not allowed.

9. Enforcement and Consequences

Activity on eBay is required to follow this policy, the eBay User Agreement, and all applicable laws, as well as respect the rights of third parties. If it doesn't, eBay may take action consistent with applicable laws and the User Agreement, and may even be legally required to do so. Such actions may include, as an example only: removing the listing or other content, issuing a warning, restricting activity, or account suspension.

10. Why eBay Has This Policy

eBay states this policy exists to make eBay a safe place to sell. To make eBay a safe place to sell, eBay holds buyers to certain standards. When buyers do not follow these standards, eBay takes action on buyers and protects sellers.